

Country Profile: Nigeria

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 15
- Official religion: None
- Official language: None
- Plurality religion: Islam (1960-2000; 2020 onwards); Christianity (2000-2020)
- Core group: None

Historical Background

Nigeria is located in West Africa and is one of the largest countries on the continent by territory. Notably, it is the most populous country in Africa. The population is roughly evenly divided between Muslims and Catholics, reflecting the geographical division of the country, where the north is predominantly Muslim and the south is Catholic. This division is rooted in the historical context of Muslim conversions from North Africa and the arrival of Catholic missionaries on Nigeria's southern coast. Nigeria gained independence from Britain in 1960, coinciding with regional changes in Cameroon. Formerly a German colony, Cameroon was split between France and Britain after World War I. Following a 1961 UN plebiscite, Northern British Cameroon opted to join Nigeria, while the Southern region remained with Cameroon. This territorial gain expanded Nigeria's borders to include Borno, Adamawa, and Taraba states, aligning with the "Taraba state people" and "Biu-Mandara language groups" in the NBP dataset. NBP considers these groups part of Nigeria from 1961, adjusting demographic data accordingly, while applying the same process for Southern Cameroons in Cameroon.¹

Since gaining independence, Nigeria has operated under a federal system of government, initially divided into three administrative regions: the Northern, Western, and Eastern Regions. Following the Biafran War, political power became increasingly concentrated in the hands of the federal government, at the expense of sub-states.² Over the decades,

¹ Ogunmupe, 2019.

² Mustapha, 2004.

however, Nigeria has undergone further decentralization, and as of 1996, it is structured as a federation comprising 36 states and one federal capital territory.

Nigeria's practice of granting preferential treatment to groups deemed “indigenous” or “native” over “settler” or “immigrant” groups has contributed to ethnic conflicts. Additionally, the inequitable distribution of oil revenues and environmental damage from extraction have exacerbated divisions. Minorities in the resource-rich Niger Delta have actively opposed oil corporations and the federal government due to environmental degradation and unfair sharing of oil wealth, often leading to demands for outright secession and violent responses from the central government. Furthermore, the federal government has been battling the armed Islamist group Boko Haram in the north, whose actions resulted in thousands of civilian deaths and continue to pose a significant challenge for the Nigerian state.³

Groups

With more than 210 million people, Nigeria is the most populous country on the African continent and its population is highly diverse.⁴ Using AMAR and EPR group lists did not result in a usable group list due to differences in how these datasets approach the concept of ethnicity. The NBP group list includes 15 groups in Nigeria. We used language Ethnologue language clusters and Joshua Project people clusters and geographic markers to determine a list of groups and subgroups. We detail below the characteristics of these groups.

Nigeria is a federal state where the Hausa-Fulani, Igbo, and Yoruba are the three main nested groups, each playing a significant role in regional governance. However, no single ethnic group, including these three, is constitutionally designated as the representative of the state, and no group's cultural traits or history are used to symbolize Nigerian nationhood. Therefore, NBP does not consider any ethnic group a core group in Nigeria.

- **Edo** is a nested group that includes several subgroups, all of which speak languages within the Edoid language cluster.⁵ The largest three linguistic

³ Minority Rights, 2023a.

⁴ Ethnologue, 2023.

⁵ Ibid.

subgroups are the Edo, Urhobo, and Isoko. The Edo represent around 1% of the population⁶ and primarily reside in Edo State in southern Nigeria.⁷

All three subgroups are predominantly Christian.⁸ Christianity first made contact with the Benin Kingdom, of which the Edo were subjects, in 1509. Despite this early start to conversions, traditional religions continued to coexist with Christianity until the late 20th century, with African traditional beliefs remaining prevalent among many Edo until then.⁹ In 1948, Edo students formed the Edo National Union, later evolving into Out Edo, a group opposing Yoruba dominance. The movement remained nonviolent until independence in 1960. To counter Edo secessionist threats, Nigeria created the Midwest Region in 1964. During the 1967 Civil War, Edo separatists briefly declared independence, but the rebellion was crushed within a month. Separatist demands reemerged in 1989, leading to the creation of Delta State in 1991.

The Urhobo subgroup, concentrated in the resource rich Niger Delta, has been advocating for self-determination of its own since the 1990s. This ongoing movement focuses on land rights, natural resources, and the preservation of their language and culture.¹⁰ Key organizations involved include the Urhobo Nationalist Movement, the Movement for the Advancement of Urhobo Nation, and the Urhobo National Youth Movement.¹¹

- The **Hausa and Fulani** (Fula) peoples are considered a single nested group, composed of the Hausa and Fulani subgroups. Both live mainly in the northern part of Nigeria¹² and practice Islam. Islam has been strongly associated with the Hausa since around 1500, while the Fulani were among the first people in West Africa to convert to Islam.¹³ Being Muslim is a significant identity marker for the Hausa-Fulani, distinguishing them from the predominantly Christian southern

⁶ Minority Rights, 2023a.

⁷ Ibid.

⁸ Joshua Project, 2023.

⁹ Osa, 2023; Eregare, 2019.

¹⁰ Ikelegbe, 2001.

¹¹ Sambanis et al., 2017, 265.

¹² SIDE, 2008; SIDE, 2013.

¹³ Joshua project, 2023a.

part of Nigeria. This religious divide has also played a significant role in contemporary Nigerian politics.

The Hausa-Fulani group constitutes around 29% of the population.¹⁴ Language is a crucial identity marker for the Hausa-Fulani, as each subgroup is primarily an ethnolinguistic group. Hausa speakers are primarily associated with the Hausa language, while the Fulani in Nigeria are linked to Nigerian Fulfulde.¹⁵

In 1949, before Nigeria's independence, the Hausa and Fulani formed the Northern People's Congress. Following the 1966 coup d'état, northern leaders considered declaring a new Republic of Hausa. The Nigerian government then proposed a loose confederation of states as a compromise. In 1994, some Hausa-Fulani renewed calls for secession.¹⁶ In 2008, tensions between Muslims and Christians in the northern Plateau State escalated. This prompted a violent response from the Nigerian police, who disproportionately targeted young Hausa-Fulani men.

- The **Igbo** are a nested group composed of numerous subgroups. The largest three, according to the Joshua Project's Igbo people cluster, are the Igbo, Ezaa, and Ikwere.¹⁷ Each group speaks its own language: Igbo, Ezaa, and Ikwere.¹⁸ Language is a crucial identity marker, as each group is primarily an ethnolinguistic entity. The Igbo make up around 18% of Nigeria's population.¹⁹ They remain concentrated in their traditional homeland, which spans the southeastern region around the Niger River.²⁰
- The Igbo are predominantly Christian today, though the group is religiously diverse, with significant factions that still primarily adhere to traditional religions and smaller shares of Muslims as well. Christian missionary efforts began in the mid-19th century. Initially met with indifference, these efforts gained traction and led to increased conversions by the early 20th century.²¹

¹⁴ CIA, 2023.

¹⁵ Ethnologue, 2023.

¹⁶ Human Rights Server, 2001.

¹⁷ Ethnologue, 2023.

¹⁸ Ibid.

¹⁹ EPR, 2021.

²⁰ Minority Rights, 2023a.

²¹ Ekechi, 1971, 103.

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- In 1966, tensions between the Igbo and the central government escalated following a series of anti-Igbo pogroms in the north, which were used to claim that the federal government was failing to protect the Igbo. In response, the leadership of the eastern region, two-thirds of whom were Igbo, declared the independent Republic of Biafra. The government reacted by surrounding and blockading Biafra, leading to a civil war and horrific famine that lasted from 1967 to 1970.
 - The **Idoma** are a nested group composed of groups that speak languages belonging to the Idomoid language cluster; the three largest groups are the Ebira, Igala, and Idoma.²² Each subgroup speaks a language that corresponds to its name: Ebira, Igala, and Idoma. The Idoma group is concentrated in the central part of Nigeria, between the states of Kogi and Benue.²³ It constitutes around 2.5% of Nigeria's population.²⁴

The Idoma group has a diverse religious composition, and religion therefore does not serve as a unifying factor within the different subgroups. About 70% of the Ebira are Muslim, with conversions to Islam increasing after the 1930s.²⁵ In contrast, the Idoma subgroup is almost entirely Christian today, with large-scale conversions occurring relatively recently, between 1940 and 1960.²⁶ The Igala are religiously mixed, practicing Christianity, traditional religions, and Islam.

- The **Ijaw** are a nested ethnic group consisting of several subgroups, all of which speak languages from the Ijoid language branch. The three largest subgroups are Izon (also known as Ijaw, Ijo, or Ezon), Kalabari (also referred to as Ijo), and Kirike (also called Okrika).²⁷ The Ijaw, primarily defined by their linguistic ties, reside mainly in Nigeria's Niger Delta region.²⁸ They represent around 10% of the country's total population.²⁹

²² Ethnologue, 2023.

²³ SIDE, 2008.

²⁴ Wikipedia, 2023a.

²⁵ Bunza and Ashafa, 2010.

²⁶ Anizoba, 2021.

²⁷ Ethnologue, 2023.

²⁸ SIDE, 2008.

²⁹ EPR, 2021.

The Ijaw are almost entirely Christian today. However, large-scale conversions to Christianity began only at the end of the 20th century, so many Ijaw still practiced their traditional religions in recent history.³⁰

The Ijaw, residing in Nigeria's oil-rich Niger Delta, have long faced state reprisals over resource control.³¹ In 1966, Ijaw youth declared the Niger Delta People's Republic, but the rebellion was quickly suppressed. The Movement for the Survival of the Ijaw Ethnic Nationality was founded in 1992, advocating for an Ijaw state, which was realized with the creation of Bayelsa State in 1996. Ethnic tensions and militant attacks on oil companies escalated in 1997, leading to a violent military crackdown in Odi in 1999.³² This reflected broader state violence against Delta minorities affected by oil extraction. While conflict intensity declined after a 2009 government amnesty, tensions persist.

- **Itsekiri** are an ethnolinguistic group residing in the Niger Delta that constitutes approximately 0.5% of Nigeria's population.³³ The group speaks the Itsekiri language, also referred to as Isekiri.³⁴ Christianity has had a presence within the group for over six centuries, and today, most Itsekiris identify as Christians.³⁵

An organized Itsekiri secessionist movement emerged in 1987 with the release of the document "Itsekiri and Delta State," which demanded a local government council exclusively for the Itsekiri people to control their lands, language, customs, and culture.³⁶ In 1999, the Itsekiri Leaders of Thought called for the creation of a new Warri state, separate from Delta State, in response to complaints about fiscal federalism, ethnic marginalization, and control over natural resources. That same year, the Warri Council of Itsekiri Chiefs sponsored a bill to establish a Federal Protected Territory for Warri Division, which would create an administrative structure dominated by Itsekiris and include a Territorial Force Command to administer justice within Warri.³⁷

³⁰ Joshua Projecta, 2023; Prezi, 2015.

³¹ Falola et al., 2018, 196–197.

³² Sambanis et al., 2017, 260

³³ Sambanis et al., 2017, 208; Ethnologue, 2023.

³⁴ Ethnologue, 2023.

³⁵ Joshua Project, 2023a.

³⁶ Obiomah, n.d.

³⁷ Sambanis et al., 2017, 261.

- The **Kanuri** consist of several subgroups within the Kanuri language cluster, with the largest being Yerwa Kanuri, Karekare, and Bade. Primarily residing in northeastern Nigeria near Lake Chad, each subgroup speaks its own language.³⁸ The Kanuri make up about 4% of Nigeria's population.³⁹

The Kanuri are predominantly Muslim, sharing the faith with other major groups in northern Nigeria, such as the Hausa and Fulani. They have been practicing Islam since the 11th century.⁴⁰

In November 1976, despite the creation of Borno State, mass Kanuri-led demonstrations erupted, demanding immediate independence. Hundreds of armed men sought to establish a separatist Kanuri administration, but the Nigerian military quickly suppressed the uprising.⁴¹

- The **Tiv** make up about 2.5% of Nigeria's population.⁴² The group is primarily located in the central-eastern part of Nigeria's Middle Belt, but it also resides in neighboring states.⁴³ Its members speak the Tiv language. The group is entirely Christian today, although conversion occurred relatively late, in the mid-20th century. Mission-led education and conversion to Christianity contributed to a sense of separateness from the predominantly Muslim northern regions that border their traditional homeland.⁴⁴

Before independence, the Tiv, along with other non-Muslim northerners, formed the Northern Non-Muslim League in 1945 to advocate for their rights. This organization became the Middle Zone League (MZL) in 1950, which campaigned for separation from the Muslim-dominated areas of northern Nigeria and the establishment of a fourth region. In the late 1950s, MZL president J.S. Tarka, an ethnic Tiv, publicly called for a distinct Middle Belt region. After Nigeria gained independence, demands for a separate Tiv state resurfaced, especially following the end of the Biafran Civil War in 1970. The creation of Benué State in 1976, with

³⁸ SIDE, 2008; Glottolog, 2023; Ethnologue, 2023.

³⁹ CIA, 2023.

⁴⁰ Joshua Project, 2023a.

⁴¹ Sambanis et al., 2017, 262.

⁴² EPR, 2021.

⁴³ SIDE, 2013.

⁴⁴ Minority Rights, 2023b.

a majority Tiv population, marked the effective conclusion of the Tiv self-determination movement.⁴⁵

- **Nupe** consist of subgroups speaking languages from the Nupoid language branch, as classified in the Joshua Project's Nupe people cluster.⁴⁶ The three largest subgroups in NBP are Nupe, Gbagyi, and Gbari, each speaking Nupe-Nupe-Tako, Gbagyi, and Gbari, respectively.⁴⁷ Primarily residing in west-central Nigeria's Middle Belt, the Nupe make up slightly less than 1% of the population.⁴⁸ The kingdom of Nupe, which reached its peak between the 16th and the late 18th centuries, was conquered and converted to Islam by the Fulani early in the 19th century.⁴⁹ Despite the fact that a significant portion of the Nupe population today is Muslim, a notable share, particularly among the Gbagyi and Gbari subgroups, continues to practice their traditional religions.⁵⁰
- **Ogoni** is a minority group concentrated in the resource-rich Niger Delta that represents around 0.5% of the population.⁵¹ The group is linguistically diverse, with NBP identifying three languages associated with the Ogoni: Tee, Khana, and Gokana, all of which fall under the Ogoni language node.⁵² British colonial forces arrived in Ogoni areas at the beginning of the 20th century, introducing the Christian faith. Today, most Ogoni have converted to Christianity, though some members of the group still retain an attachment to their traditional religion.⁵³

Founded in 1990, the Movement for the Survival of the Ogoni Peoples (MOSOP) seeks greater self-determination for the Ogoni people and has consistently advocated for its goals through non-violent means.⁵⁴ Throughout the 1990s, tensions escalated as the Ogoni protested against the Shell Petroleum Development Company's oil extraction in their homeland, prompting violent crackdowns by Nigerian security forces. These actions led to widespread killings,

⁴⁵ Sambanis et al., 2017, 264.

⁴⁶ Ethnologue, 2023; Joshua Project, 2023b.

⁴⁷ Ethnologue, 2023.

⁴⁸ SIDE, 2010. SIDE, 2013; Minority Rights, 2023a.

⁴⁹ Minority Rights, 2023a.

⁵⁰ Joshua Project, 2023a.

⁵¹ Minority Rights, 2023; EPR, 2021.

⁵² Ethnologue, 2023.

⁵³ Joshua Project, 2023a.

⁵⁴ Sambanis et al., 2017, 263.

the destruction of villages, and significant displacement within the Ogoni community.

- The **Yoruba** are a nested group of communities speaking various Yoruboid languages, primarily concentrated in southwestern Nigeria. NBP categorizes the Yoruba as comprising the Oyo Yoruba, Egba-Yoruba, and Awori subgroups, which align with the Joshua Project's Yoruba people cluster. These groups speak Yoruba, a language within the Yoruboid branch, which also includes 13 other languages.⁵⁵ The Yoruba are one of the three largest ethnic groups in Nigeria, constituting approximately 21% of the population.⁵⁶

The Yoruba are religiously diverse, reflecting the history of different religious influences in Yoruba-dominant areas. Today, more than half of the group is Christian, and the rest adhere to Islam.⁵⁷ Predominantly Muslim groups have bordered Yoruba lands to the north since the 11th or 12th century, while Christian missionaries arrived in Yorubaland in the mid-19th century.⁵⁸ This led to large-scale conversions by the end of the century, reflecting the significant share of Yoruba that identify as Christian today.⁵⁹

In 1966–1967, Yoruba leaders advocated for secession from the newly independent Nigerian state. The Odua People's Congress (OPC) was formed in 1994 to promote Yoruba self-determination and serve as an ethnic vigilante group, marking the second phase of the movement. As of 2012, the OPC remained active.⁶⁰

- **Ibibio-Efik** is a collective term for related ethnic groups residing in the lower Cross River region in the southeastern part of Nigeria.⁶¹ The nested group comprises around 3.5% of the population.⁶² The largest three subgroups within this group are

⁵⁵ Joshua Project, 2023b.

⁵⁶ EPR, 2021.

⁵⁷ Joshua Project, 2023a.

⁵⁸ Comstock, 1979. Peel, 2000.

⁵⁹ Ibid.

⁶⁰ Sambanis et al., 2017, 266

⁶¹ SIDE, 2008; SIDE, 2010; SIDE, 2013.

⁶² CIA, 2023.

Ibibio, Efik, and Anaang. Each subgroup speaks a language that bears its name: Ibibio, Efik, and Anaang.⁶³

The Ibibio-Efik are predominantly Christians.⁶⁴ Christian missionaries began arriving in Ibibio areas in the mid-19th century, leading to substantial conversions by the 1920s.⁶⁵ In contrast, the Efik were slower to adopt Christianity, and significant conversions only occurred in the 1950s.⁶⁶ The Anaang also converted later, starting in the 1920s.⁶⁷

In the early 1900s, tensions began to emerge due to the migration of Ibos to Ibibioland, also called Calabar, in southeastern Nigeria within Akwa Ibom State and Cross River State, where the Ibibios were predominantly concentrated. In 1944, the Ibibio State Union was established to restrict Ibo immigration and advocate for a separate Calabar region within Nigeria. Following Nigeria's independence, Ibibio demands for separation intensified, leading to calls for complete separation by 1965. In 1967, the new constitution created 12 federal states, granting the Ibibios their own South-Eastern State. In 1976, the Yoruba further demanded the division of their state to separate their southern settlements from northern ethnic groups. While ethnic nationalism has continued, no formal organization has actively pushed for self-determination since then.⁶⁸

- The **Plateau Voltaic** nested group consists of communities that speak Platoid languages, a subgroup of the Voltaic language branch, and are primarily located in Plateau State, north-central Nigeria. The three largest subgroups by number of speakers are Berom, Jju (also known as Kaje), and Tarok, each speaking a language that shares its name.⁶⁹ The nested group comprises approximately 2.3% of the population.⁷⁰

Plateau Voltaic groups are religiously diverse, practicing Christianity, Islam, and their traditional religions; however, the share of Christians is the largest.⁷¹ This

⁶³ AMAR, 2023.

⁶⁴ Joshua Project, 2023a.

⁶⁵ Abasiattai, 1989.

⁶⁶ Hackett, 2013.

⁶⁷ Essien, 2010.

⁶⁸ Sambanis et al., 2017, 258.

⁶⁹ Ethnologue, 2023.

⁷⁰ Ibid.

⁷¹ Joshua Project, 2023a.

stems from the historical religious influence in Nigeria's Middle Belt. While these groups largely resisted early Islamic expansion, colonial rule proved more difficult to withstand, ultimately leading to gradual conversions among the region's subgroups.⁷²

- The **Taraba** people group in the NBP dataset consists of ethnolinguistic communities whose languages are primarily spoken in Taraba State and are not already classified under other ethnic groups listed in NBP's Nigeria group list.⁷³ Accordingly, the largest three groups that meet these criteria are Mumuye, Mambila, and Jukun. The nested group represents around 1.6% of Nigeria's population.⁷⁴

The group is concentrated in Nigeria's Taraba State, in the northeastern part of the country bordering Cameroon.⁷⁵ The languages spoken by the subgroups are Mumuye, Nigerian Mambila, and Jukun Takum.⁷⁶ While a small share of the subgroups has converted to Islam or Christianity, most of the Taraba State people continue to practice their traditional religions.⁷⁷

- The **Biu-Mandara** people group in the NBP dataset consists of ethnic communities from Adamawa State in northeastern Nigeria, near the Cameroon border, that are not included in other NBP groups. The three largest subgroups, based on the number of speakers, are Kamwe (Higi), Marghi, and Kilba.⁷⁸ These subgroups speak languages from the Chadic language cluster, specifically the Biu-Mandara branch, which is why the NBP dataset classifies them under this linguistic designation rather than their geographic concentration in Adamawa State. Speakers of Biu-Mandara languages in Nigeria make up approximately 1.7% of the total population.⁷⁹

The languages associated with the ethnolinguistic subgroups of the Biu-Mandara group are Kamwe, Central Marghi, and Nya Huba.⁸⁰ The group is religiously diverse,

⁷² Danfulani, 2001.

⁷³ Ethnologue, 2023; Wikipedia, 2023b.

⁷⁴ Federal Republic of Nigeria, 2006.

⁷⁵ SIDE, 2010; SIDE, 2013.

⁷⁶ Ethnologue, 2023.

⁷⁷ Joshua Project, 2023a.

⁷⁸ Ethnologue, 2023.

⁷⁹ Ibid.

⁸⁰ Ibid.

although the most significant share of believers in all three subgroups adhere to Christianity.⁸¹ Unlike Islam, which is the predominant religion in the neighboring northern part of Nigeria, Christian missionaries were more successful in penetrating and converting individuals living in Nigeria's Middle Belt.⁸² This explains why a significant share of the Biu-Mandara linguistic cluster is Christian today, with a much smaller portion practicing Islam or continuing to follow traditional religions.

State Profile

Official Languages and Official Religion

Nigeria does not recognize any language as the official state language, nor does it recognize any religion as the official state religion.

Education Policies

In the final years of colonial rule, Nigeria lacked a unified state education system. In 1955, the Western and Eastern regions introduced universal free primary education, followed by the federal government in Lagos. Due to fewer educational facilities in the Northern Region, the federal government focused on accelerating development there. Since independence, the federal and regional governments have maintained free primary education, with fees for secondary and higher levels. Education falls under regional jurisdiction, governed by regional education laws, although the overall system remains similar across regions.⁸³

Language Education Policies

The 1977 National Policy on Education emphasizes the importance of learning major Nigerian languages—Hausa, Igbo, and Yoruba—to foster national unity. While the federal government promotes the teaching of English, Hausa, Yoruba, and Igbo, state (regional) governments are responsible for regional and local languages. The policy mandates that primary school instruction should start with the child's mother tongue or local language, transitioning to English later; however, it is more of an aim than an obligatory policy,

⁸¹ Joshua Project, 2023a.

⁸² Abdulkadir, 2011.

⁸³ UNESCO, 1971.

meaning that NBP does not consider languages other than Hausa, Yoruba, and Igbo as mediums of instruction during this early post-independence period.⁸⁴

Compared to the 1977 policy, the 2004 National Policy on Education is more specific about the implementation of mother tongue education. It mandates that the medium of instruction in primary schools should be the language of the community for the first three years, with English gradually taking over from the fourth year.⁸⁵ NBP thus considers all languages associated with ethnic groups in Nigeria as languages of instruction in public primary schools where they are spoken as mother tongues and as a language class from 4th grade onwards in those parts of the country where they are dominant. In secondary schools, they are taught as optional language classes.

There are no restrictions on the languages that can serve as languages of instruction in private schools.

Religious Education Policies

The 1960 Nigerian Constitution ensures freedom of conscience by stating that individuals attending educational institutions cannot be compelled to receive religious instruction or participate in religious ceremonies that are not aligned with their own religion. This provision, which remains consistent in subsequent constitutions, indicates that private religious institutions can provide religious instruction according to their faith, but public schools are subject to different regulations. Reforms, including government takeovers of church-run schools and the National Policy on Education, later mandated the teaching of Christian religious knowledge for Christian groups and Islamic religious knowledge for Muslim groups in all primary schools. Traditional African religions are not mentioned as a compulsory religion class.⁸⁶

Since the exact start date of this policy in the post-independence period is uncertain, NBP considers the policy as in effect from 1960* to 2020.

⁸⁴ Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1977; Albaugh, 2014, 303.

⁸⁵ Federal Republic of Nigeria, 2004; L'Aménagement linguistique dans le monde, 2023. Albaugh, 2014, 303;

⁸⁶ RAS, 2023; Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1960; Jawoniyi, 2009.

Bans and Restrictions

Religious Symbols and Clothing (2013–2016)

Between 2013 and 2016, Nigeria saw legal disputes over religious symbols in public schools. In October 2014, a Lagos High Court upheld a restriction on wearing the hijab in public primary and secondary schools except during religious instruction and prayer. However, by June 2016, the Osun State High Court overturned a 2013 ban, ruling that female students could wear the hijab in government schools. Later, a Lagos State Court of Appeals also lifted the ban, stating it infringed upon the religious rights of Muslim girls.⁸⁷

Restrictions on Proselytizing (1999–2007)

Between 1999 and 2007, a general ban on public proselytizing was enforced in several northern states following violence related to the adoption of Sharia law in the Kaduna state in February 2000. Although religious publications were still distributed, proselytizing faced restrictions, especially in the north, while it was less restricted in the south. Some states began to relax these restrictions informally, allowing certain public proselytizing. Despite the 2005 court ruling declaring the ban unconstitutional, certain states continued to restrict large public religious gatherings to prevent sectarian violence.⁸⁸

Restrictions on Religious Publications (2000–2003)

From 2000 to 2003, there were sporadic restrictions on religious publications. In the Muslim dominated Zamfara State, the government limited the distribution of Christian literature, with state-run media often excluding Christian content. Conversely, similar restrictions on Muslim publications were noted in southern Christian-dominated states.⁸⁹

Demographic Engineering and Violence

In Nigeria, a highly discriminatory system known as the “indigene” vs. “settler” distinction grants preferential treatment to Indigenous ethnic groups in areas such as emolument in the public sector, for example in schools and in access to land. This system, in force since independence, varies by state, with each federal state having its own criteria for determining who is considered Indigenous. Initially, the post-independence Nigerian Federation was divided into three administrative regions, where most people were

⁸⁷ U.S. Department of State, 2014–2016.

⁸⁸ U.S. Department of State, 1999–2007.

⁸⁹ U.S. Department of State, 2000–2003.

regarded as Indigenous to their respective regions. However, with the increase in federal states to 36 and one federal capital territory since 1996, many individuals and ethnic groups have been classified as non-Indigenous in states where they have lived for generations.⁹⁰ This system is not included in the NBPDP because it does not target any specific ethnic group and cannot be captured by the dataset.

State-Based Violence

State-Based Violence against Hausa-Fulani

On November 28–29, 2008, violent clashes between Muslim and Christian groups in Jos, Plateau State, resulted in hundreds of deaths. During the unrest, Nigerian police and military forces were responsible for over 130 arbitrary killings, primarily targeting young Muslim men from the Hausa-Fulani ethnic group. Human Rights Watch documented 133 of these killings but suspects the actual number is much higher. Although most inter-communal violence occurred on November 28, the police and military carried out the majority of the killings on November 29, the same day Plateau State Governor Jonah Jang issued a “shoot-on-sight” order.⁹¹

State-Based Violence against Igbo

The Nigerian Civil War, also known as the Biafran War, was a conflict fought between the Nigerian government and the secessionist Republic of Biafra, an area predominantly inhabited by the Igbo ethnic group. The war lasted from 1967 to 1970. It followed the 1966 anti-Igbo pogroms, a period of violence from May 29 to September 29, 1966. During this time, organized attacks against Igbo communities in northern and western Nigeria resulted in an estimated 3,000 to 30,000 deaths. The actual Civil War began on May 30, 1967, when General Emeka Ojukwu declared the eastern region of Nigeria, where the Igbo are concentrated, an independent state called Biafra. The Nigerian government responded with a military campaign to reclaim the region, leading to Biafra’s surrender in January 1970. The conflict was exacerbated by a government-imposed blockade of Biafra, which caused severe shortages and led to an estimated 1 million deaths from malnutrition and disease. Accurate estimates of the total death toll are difficult to

⁹⁰ Human Rights Watch, 2006a; Human Rights Watch, 2006b; Sayne, 2012.

⁹¹ Human Rights Watch, 2009.

determine, with figures ranging from 500,000 to 6 million due to issues with data reliability and reporting.⁹²

State-Based Violence against Ijaw

In 1999, the Nigerian government launched a violent military operation against the Ijaw town of Odi in Bayelsa State, an oil-producing region in the Niger Delta. The attack followed the killing of seven policemen by an armed gang with no apparent political agenda. Odi, home to about 15,000 people, was targeted after President Olusegun Obasanjo threatened to declare a state of emergency if the perpetrators were not captured. Before the deadline, the Nigerian army moved in, engaged in brief clashes, and razed the town, sparing only a few buildings. Hundreds of unarmed civilians may have been killed in the process. Although there was no explicit intent to target the Ijaw as an ethnic group, Odi's identity as a predominantly Ijaw town suggests that the authorities were aware of the population's ethnicity, which is why NBP classifies this as an episode of state-based violence against the Ijaw ethnic group. The operation's stated plan included protecting oil company assets such as pipelines and rig terminals, reinforcing a broader pattern of targeting Delta minorities who live on land exploited for oil extraction. These groups, including the Ijaw, have been repeatedly targeted by the government, oil companies, and private military forces.⁹³

State-Based Violence against Tiv

From October 22 to 24, 2001, several hundred soldiers of the Nigerian army carried out a military operation in Benue State, central-eastern Nigeria, killing more than two hundred unarmed Tiv civilians and destroying homes, shops, and public buildings across some seven towns and villages. The operation was a reprisal for the killing of 19 soldiers, allegedly by members of the Tiv ethnic group. Those killed were victims of collective punishment, targeted solely because of their ethnic identity. Survivors reported that the soldiers made explicit comments indicating the Tiv were being punished as a group for the deaths of the soldiers. This incident is referred to as the Benue State Massacre.⁹⁴

⁹² Anderton, n.d.; World Peace Foundation, 2015; Targeted Mass Killing (TMK) Dataset, 2022; Ulfelder and Valentino (UV), 2008.

⁹³ UCDP Ethnic One-Sided Violence Dataset, 2023; Wikipedia, 2023c; Human Rights Watch, 1999; Imasogie, 2014.

⁹⁴ UCDP, n.d.; Human Rights Watch, 2002.

State-Based Violence against Ibibio-Efik

From January to December 2004 the Niger Delta was engulfed by recurrent inter-communal fighting and heavy-handed security operations. Contemporary reports record a string of deadly episodes: small attacks and reprisals through the year; larger clashes such as the Port Harcourt fighting of 3–5 June (reported as at least 50 killed); a month of violence in September (roughly 100 killed); and a separate two-week offensive that some sources estimate at about 500 deaths.⁹⁵

State-Based Violence against Ogoni

Starting in the early 1990s, tensions escalated as the Ogoni people began protesting the presence of the Shell Petroleum Development Company of Nigeria (SPDC), which was extracting oil in their traditional homeland of Ogoniland. In response, government forces launched violent crackdowns. In October 1990, mobile police attacked the community of Umuechem, resulting in the deaths of about 80 people. By mid 1993, the violence intensified as Nigerian security forces began to target the Ogoni deliberately. Although the government attempted to attribute these attacks to intercommunal tensions, evidence pointed to direct state involvement. The military carried out raids on Ogoni villages, targeting communities based on their actual or suspected ties to the protest movement. Throughout the summer of 1994, these raids became an almost nightly occurrence. By July, reports confirmed that approximately 800 Ogonis had been killed by the military since late May. A 2002 report estimated that the attacks resulted in around 1,000 deaths, the destruction of multiple villages, and the displacement of 30,000 people by the end of 1994.⁹⁶

Constitutions and Laws

Constitutional Provisions

The constitutional history of Nigeria reflects a long history of authoritarian rule and divisive internal conflicts. Indeed, Nigeria experienced over 30 years of military rule starting in 1966 with a military coup and the collapse of the First Nigerian Republic, extending until the last military government that ended in 1999. This period also encompassed the devastating Civil War from 1967 to 1970. Nigeria's federal structure has undergone significant transformation, expanding from four federal sub-units in 1966 to 36

⁹⁵ MAR, 2006.

⁹⁶ Anderton, n.d.; Human Rights Watch, 1995; Amnesty International, 2007.

by 1999, as reflected in the country's constitution. Since 1999, Nigeria has experienced its longest uninterrupted period of civilian rule.⁹⁷

The 1960 Constitution was the country's first independent constitution. The document does not mention any ethnic group and does not designate an official state language. It recognizes universal freedom of religion in Article 23.⁹⁸ Similarly, the 1963 Constitution does not recognize any group nor specify an official state language, with religious freedom guaranteed in Article 24.⁹⁹

The 1979 Constitution was a military constitution, which, like the previous two, did not acknowledge any specific ethnic group in Nigeria and did not recognize an official state language. Article 35 guaranteed universal religious freedom.¹⁰⁰ The 1989 Constitution, also written under a military government, maintains the same provisions as earlier constitutions, with religious freedom guaranteed in Article 37. The 1993 Constitution is not a new constitution but rather a reinstated 1989 constitution, following the failure to create and introduce a new democratic constitution in 1993.

Finally, the 1999 Constitution is the first civilian constitution in over 30 years. It does not mention ethnic groups, designate an official state language, or recognize universal religious freedom. The constitution declares that no religion will be granted official status, as stated in Article 10.

Islam is explicitly recognized in Article 277, which establishes the institutionalization of Sharia law for Muslims under the jurisdiction of specific northern states.¹⁰¹

Citizenship Laws

No ethnic group in Nigeria has been excluded from acquiring national citizenship. The first legislative act concerning citizenship rights after independence was the 1960 Citizenship Ordinance, which included provisions for citizenship by registration and naturalization. The term "registration" is repeated in the 1961 Citizenship Act. Since the meaning of registration or the criteria required to qualify for it are not clearly explained, NBP treats the

⁹⁷ Suberu, 2019.

⁹⁸ Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1960.

⁹⁹ Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1963.

¹⁰⁰ Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1979; Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1989.

¹⁰¹ Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1999.

immediate post-independence period as having no information on Nigeria's citizenship access regime.

From 1963, citizenship acquisition was governed by Article 11 of the 1963 Constitution, which ensured unconditional birthright citizenship. This policy changed with the 1974 decree that revoked birthright citizenship and repealed the 1960 and 1961 Citizenship Acts. The *jus sanguinis* principle was further reinforced in the 1979 Constitution and reaffirmed in the 1999 Constitution, which remains in effect today.¹⁰²

National Anthem(s)

Since independence, Nigeria has had two national anthems. The first, "Nigeria We Hail Thee," was adopted in 1960 and remained in use until it was replaced under the military dictatorship in 1978. Despite the return to civilian rule since, the 1978 anthem, "Arise Oh Compatriots, Nigeria's Call Obey," has remained in force. Both anthems are written in English. The 1960 anthem includes religious and military references and makes specific mention of Nigeria's national territory. The 1978 anthem also contains explicit religious references and celebrates the country's ancestors. In 2024, the 1960 anthem was reinstated as the national anthem, a decision that has faced criticism. Among the concerns raised is the fact that "Nigeria We Hail Thee" was written by a British expatriate, drawing objections related to its colonial origins.¹⁰³ However as NBP only collects information until 2020, this change is not reflected in the dataset.

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¹⁰² Manby et al., 2020.

¹⁰³ National Anthems.info, 2023a; National Anthems.info, 2023b.

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